

Bengali, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Bengali set in
Noto Sans Bengali (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This book teaches Bengali one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Bengali letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read নমস্কার *and* learn what it means in the same few minutes. (A reader who already reads Bengali simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Bengali (*Bāṅglā*) is an **Indo-Aryan** language — descended, like Hindi, Marathi, and Punjabi, from Sanskrit — and the mother tongue of Bengal: West Bengal in India and all of Bangladesh, some 250 million speakers, the seventh-largest language on earth. It is the language of Tagore, and the only one to have furnished the national anthem of *two* nations. One habit runs through the whole book and is worth stating up front: Bengali’s inherent vowel is **ô** (not “a”), its *s* tilts to **sh**, and its *v* collapses to **b** — so Sanskrit *namaskāra* is spoken *nômoshkar*. Learn to hear that shift and every Sanskrit-derived word becomes legible. Roots are traced to Sanskrit and, where they reach, to the wider family that also gave English its words — every form supplied in full.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Bengali out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 — share it, adapt it, teach from it.

Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings	1
1.1 নমস্কার (<i>nômoshkar</i>) — “hello”	1
1.2 ধন্যবাদ (<i>dhônyobād</i>) — “thank you”	2
1.3 হ্যাঁ / না (<i>hyā / nā</i>) — “yes” and “no”	2
1.4 আচ্ছা (<i>āchchhā</i>) — “okay / I see”	3
1.5 আসি (<i>āshi</i>) — “I’ll be going” (goodbye)	3
1.6 Recap	4
2 Introducing Yourself	5
2.1 নাম (<i>nām</i>) — “name,” a word older than Europe	5
2.2 আমার (<i>āmār</i>) — “my”	6
2.3 আমার নাম... (<i>āmār nām ...</i>) — “my name is...,” with no “is”	6
2.4 তুমি / আপনি (<i>tumi / āpni</i>) — “you,” three ways	6
2.5 কি (<i>ki</i>) — “what”	7
2.6 তোমার নাম কি? (<i>tomār nām ki</i>) — “what’s your name?”	7
2.7 আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো (<i>ālāp kore bhālo lāglo</i>) — “pleased to meet you”	7
2.8 The whole exchange	7
3 How Are You?	9
3.1 কেমন (<i>kēmon</i>) — “how,” another of the k- questions	9
3.2 তুমি কেমন আছো? — “how are you?”	9
3.3 আমি (<i>āmi</i>) — “I,” cousin of English <i>am</i>	10
3.4 ভালো (<i>bhālo</i>) — “well,” and how to answer	10
3.5 কোনো ব্যাপার না (<i>kono bāpār nā</i>) — “no matter”	10
3.6 The whole exchange	11

4 Farewells	13
4.1 আবাব (<i>ābār</i>) — “again”	13
4.2 দেখা হবে (<i>dækhā hōbe</i>) — “(we) will meet”	13
4.3 আবাব দেখা হবে — “we’ll meet again”	14
4.4 কাল দেখা হবে (<i>kāl dækhā hōbe</i>) — “see you tomorrow”	14
4.5 The farewells	14
5 The First Verbs	15
5.1 বলা (<i>bôlā</i>) — “to speak,” your first full verb	15
5.2 আমি বাংলা বলি — “I speak Bengali”	15
5.3 থাকা (<i>thākā</i>) — “to live, to stay”	16
5.4 কাজ করা (<i>kāj kôrā</i>) — “to work”	16
5.5 Sentences about yourself	17
6 Numbers One to Five	19
6.1 ek dui tin chār pāch	19
7 The Core Verbs	23
7.1 hōwā	23
7.2 jāwā	25
7.3 āsā	26
7.4 khāwā	28
7.5 dækhā	29
7.6 jānā	31
8 The Mind and the Page	33
8.1 bhābā	33
8.2 bojhā	35
8.3 pôṛā	36
8.4 lekhā	38
9 Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking	41
9.1 neowā	41
9.2 jījñāsā kôrā	43
9.3 sāhājjo kôrā	44
9.4 bhālo lāgā	46
10 Tea, Water, Milk, and Rice	49
10.1 chā	49
10.2 jōl	51
10.3 dudh	52

10.4 bhāt	53
11 Friend, Family, Brother, and Sister	55
11.1 bôndhu	55
11.2 pôribār	56
11.3 bhāi	58
11.4 bon	59
12 Eye, Mouth, Nose, and Heart	61
12.1 chokh	61
12.2 mukh	62
12.3 nāk	64
12.4 hridoy	65
The Bengali script (reference)	67

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Bengali greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Bengali script and the one sound-shift that turns every Sanskrit word into something recognisably *Bengali*. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs.

1.1 নমস্কার (*nômoshkar*) — “hello”

The letters in this word

(If you already read Bengali, skim this.) Bengali runs **left to right** under a top line, and every consonant carries a built-in vowel — but in Bengali that vowel is **ô** (an open “o”), *not* “a.” ন *nô*, ম *mô*, ক *kô*, র *rô*. A **vowel sign** changes it (াঁ *ā*); a *hasanta* under ঞ strips the vowel so it joins the next as a conjunct: ঞ + ক → ঞ্চ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নমস্কার is the *same word* as the Sanskrit *namaskāra* behind Hindi’s and Marathi’s greeting (*namas* “a bow” + *kāra* “the making of”) — but listen to what Bengali does to it. The inherent “a” becomes **ô**, and *s* shifts to **sh**, so the written *namaskāra* is *spoken* **nômoshkar**. That one habit — *a*→*ô*, *s*→*sh* — is the fingerprint of Bengali, and once you hear it you can un-shift almost any word back to its Sanskrit cousin.

Why it’s said this way

Nômoshkar, palms together, is the everyday respectful greeting among Bengali Hindus and in formal speech generally — hello and, often, goodbye. Bengali Muslims more often exchange *as-salāmu alaïkum* /

nāmāskār by community; *nômoshkar* is the broad, secular-to-Hindu default. Bengali is the language of Tagore — the only tongue to have written the national anthem of *two* countries, India and Bangladesh.

1.2 ধন্যবাদ (*dhônyobād*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ধ *dhô* (breathy *d*), ব *bô*, দ *dô*, and the conjunct ন্য (ন + য *y*). With the া sign, read ধন্যবাদ as *dhô · nyo · bā · d*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ধন্যবাদ is Sanskrit *dhanya* (“worthy”) + *vāda* (“a saying”) — the very “thank you” Hindi (*dhanyavād*), Marathi, and Punjabi use. Two Bengali quirks show at once: the inherent *a*→*ô* again (*dhônyobād*), and **no separate “v”** — Bengali has only ব, so Sanskrit *vāda* is spoken *bād*. *V* becoming *b* is a Bengali signature (think of *Bishnu* for *Vishnu*).

1.3 হ্যাঁ / না (*hyā / nā*) — “yes” and “no”

The letters in this word

New: হ *hô*, the *y-phola* ঞ that glides the sound, and the nasal mark *chandrabinḍu* ণ̃ (a moon-with-dot) that sends the vowel through the nose. না is simply ন + া *nā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

হ্যাঁ (*hyā*, “yes”) and না (*nā*, “no”). That “no” rides the ancient negative *na-* — the same Proto-Indo-European **ne* behind English **no**, **not**, **none**, Latin *nōn*, and Hindi *nahīṇ*. Bengali kept it at its shortest, bare *nā*: the family resemblance to English *no* is right on the surface.

1.4 আচ্ছা (āchchhā) — “okay / I see”

The letters in this word

New: আ — the **independent** vowel ā, the shape a word uses when it *starts* with a vowel (a built-in vowel rides a consonant; a standalone one gets its own letter). Then the doubled ছ (চ *ch* + ছ *chh*). Read আচ্ছা as ā · chchhā.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আচ্ছা (āchchhā) is the all-purpose “okay, alright, I see, go on” — a true workhorse of spoken Bengali, from Sanskrit *acchā* (“good, clear”). It is the little word that keeps a conversation moving; a Bengali speaker will pepper speech with āchchhā... āchchhā the way an English speaker says “right... right.”

1.5 আসি (āshi) — “I’ll be going” (goodbye)

The letters in this word

New: স again — here truly “sh” — and the ি sign (*i*), which in Bengali is *written before* the consonant it follows but *read after* it. আসি = আ + সি, ā-shi.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আসি (āshi) literally means “**I come**” — from the verb *āsā* (“to come,” Sanskrit root shared with Hindi *ānā*). Yet it is how Bengalis say *goodbye*. Never “I’m leaving” (unlucky, too final) but “I’ll come [again]” — আসি or the fuller *āschhi* (“I am coming”). It is the very same “promise of return” farewell Tamil and Marathi reach for: a whole culture’s optimism folded into one verb.

Grammar Lens

Notice Bengali marks no gender on the verb — *āshi* is “I come” whether a man or a woman says it. That sets it apart from Marathi (*yeto* m./*yete* f.) and Hindi, and makes Bengali verbs, in this one respect, simpler than its neighbours’.

1.6 Recap

Bengali		Meaning
নমস্কার	<i>nômoshkar</i>	hello / goodbye
ধন্যবাদ	<i>dhônyobād</i>	thank you
হ্যাঁ / না	<i>hyā / nā</i>	yes / no
আচ্ছা	<i>āchchhā</i>	okay / I see
আসি	<i>āshi</i>	goodbye (“I’ll come again”)

One habit unlocks this whole chapter: Bengali’s inherent vowel is **ô**, not “a,” and its *s* leans toward **sh** while its *v* collapses to **b**. Hear those shifts and the “foreign” *nômoshkar* and *dhônyobād* snap back into the Sanskrit *namaskāra* and *dhanyavāda* you already knew. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *āmār nām...* (“my name...”) — and Bengali’s *tumi* / *āpnī* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

আমার নাম মিরাল (āmar nām Mira — “My name is Mira.”)
তোমার নাম কি? (tomār nām kī — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and root, then assembled.

2.1 নাম (nām) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

ন (nô) + া (long ā, overriding the inherent ô) + ম (mô) → নাম (nām).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নাম (nām) ← Sanskrit *nāman*, from Proto-Indo-European **h₃nómn*, — the *same* root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**), and Greek *onoma*. Bengali *nām* and English *name* are cousins from before either language existed.

2.2 আমার (*āmār*) — “my”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আমার (*āmār*, “my”) is the possessive of আমি (*āmi*, “I”), on the first-person stem *ām-* ← Sanskrit *asmad*. Buried in it is the same ancient **m-** of English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *mē*.

Grammar Lens

No gender here. *āmār* never changes for gender, where Hindi and Punjabi have *merā* (m.) / *merī* (f.). Bengali threw grammatical gender away entirely — one of its great simplifications, which you will meet again and again.

2.3 আমার নাম... (*āmār nām ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

আমার (my) + নাম (name) + name = “my name ...” → “my name is...” *Āmār nām Arun*.

Grammar Lens

Bengali drops “is” in the present. There is *no verb*: Bengali sets “my name” beside “Arun” and the “is” is understood. This is the **zero copula** — for present-tense equations (X is Y), Bengali needs no “to be” (like Tamil, and unlike Hindi’s *merā nām ...hai*). A verb returns only for a *state* or *place* (Chapter 3).

2.4 তুমি / আপনি (*tumi / āpni*) — “you,” three ways

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

তুমি (*tumi*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE *tū — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*. Bengali grades respect in **three**: তুই (*tui*, intimate), তুমি (*tumi*, familiar), আপনি (*āpni*, respectful) — like Hindi’s *tū/tum/āp*. For a first meeting, *āpni*.

2.5 কি (*ki*) — “what”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কি (*ki*, “what”) ← the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. Bengali’s questions nearly all begin with *k-*: *ki* (what), *ke* (who), *kôbe* (when), *kôthāy* (where), *kēmon* (how).

2.6 তোমার নাম কি? (*tomār nām ki*) — “what’s your name?”

তোমার (*tomār*, “your,” from *tumi*) + নাম (name) + কি (what) = “**your name what?**” — still *no* “*is.*” The respectful “your” is আপনার (*āpnār*, from *āpnī*): *āpnār nām ki?* — the one for a stranger.

2.7 আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো (*ālāp kore bhālo lāglo*) — “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো — “having made [your] acquaintance, it felt good.” The key word আলাপ (*ālāp*, “acquaintance, conversation”) is **Sanskrit** (*ālāpa*, *ā-* “toward” + *lap* “to speak”) — the same *ālāp* that names the slow, exploratory opening of a *rāga*, where a musician “converses” with the notes.

2.8 The whole exchange

Bengali	English
আমার নাম মির।	My name is Mira.
আপনার নাম কি?	What’s your name?
আমার নাম অরুণ।	My name is Arun.
আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nām* (Sanskrit *nāman*, English *name*), *āmār* (first-person *ām-*, no gender), *ki* (root *ka-*, English *what*), *ālāp* (Sanskrit “conversing”). Two Bengali habits already: the **zero copula** (no “is”), and

no grammatical gender. Next chapter: *tumi kēmon āchho?* (“how are you?”).

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, Bengali brings back a verb “to be”:

তুমি কেমন আছো? (*tumi kēmon āchho* — “How are you?”)
আমি ভালো আছি, ধন্যবাদ। (*āmi bhālo āchhi, dhōnnobad* — “I’m well, thank you.”)

3.1 কেমন (*kēmon*) — “how,” another of the k-questions

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কেমন (*kēmon*, “how, of what kind”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. Bengali’s questions nearly all begin with *k-*: *ki*, *ke*, *kôbe*, *kôthāy*, *kēmon*.

3.2 তুমি কেমন আছো? — “how are you?”

The new word is আছো (*āchho*, “are you”), from the verb আছা (*āchhā*, “to be, exist, have”) + the familiar-you ending. So তুমি কেমন আছো? is “you how are?”, the verb last. Respectful: আপনি কেমন আছেন? (*āpni kēmon āchhen?*).

Grammar Lens

Now the copula returns. Chapter 2’s zero copula covers *equations* (*āmār nām Arun*). But “how are you?” asks about a *state* — how you

exist — and for that Bengali uses a real verb, **আছা** (*āchhā*). No verb for “my name is Arun”; a real verb for “how are you.”

3.3 আমি (*āmi*) — “I,” cousin of English *am*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আমি (*āmi*, “I”) descends from Sanskrit **अस्मि** (*asmi*, “I am”), from PIE **h₁es-* — the “to be” root that gives English **am** and Latin *sum*. So Bengali’s word for “I” is, at the root, a form of “**am**”: “I” and “am” were once one word. Its possessive is *āmār* (“my”).

3.4 ভালো (*bhālo*) — “well,” and how to answer

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভালো (*bhālo*, “good, well, fine”) is the everyday Bengali “good,” likely from Sanskrit **ভদ্র** (*bhadra*, “good, auspicious”). It fills the language: *bhālo lāge* (“[I] like it”), *bhālobāsā* (“love,” literally “good-dwelling”). The reply: আমি ভালো আছি (*āmi bhālo āchhi*), “I am well.”

3.5 কোনো ব্যাপার না (*kono bāpār nā*) — “no matter”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কোনো ব্যাপার না literally “[it’s] **no matter**” — *kono* (“any”) + ব্যাপার (*bāpār*, “matter, affair”) + না (*nā*, “not”). It serves as “it’s nothing / you’re welcome.” *Bāpār* is **Sanskrit** (*vyāpāra*, “dealing”), and *nā* you met in Chapter 1 — the ancient negative, PIE **ne*, behind English **no**, **not**, **none**.

3.6 The whole exchange

Bengali	English
তুমি কেমন আছো?	How are you?
আমি ভালো আছি, ধন্যবাদ।	I'm well, thank you.
কোনো ব্যাপার না।	No matter / you're welcome.

Every atom traced: *kēmon* (the *k*- questions), *āmi* (Sanskrit *asmi*, English *am*), *bhālo* (Sanskrit *bhadra*), *nā* (PIE *ne, English *no*). Next chapter: the farewells.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the tender আসি (*āshi*, “I’ll come [again]”). Its fuller, everyday form:

আবার দেখা হবে! (*ābār dākhā hōbe* — “We’ll meet again!”)

4.1 আবার (*ābār*) — “again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আবার (*ābār*, “again”) is a native Indo-Aryan adverb with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar job: it turns a parting into a promise. Add it to Chapter 1’s *āshi* and you can say “we’ll meet *again*.”

4.2 দেখা হবে (*dākhā hōbe*) — “(we) will meet”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দেখা হবে literally “[a] seeing will happen” — দেখা (*dākhā*, “seeing,” from *dākhā* “to see”) + হবে (*hōbe*, “will be/happen,” future of *hōwā* “to be/become”). Bengali says “a meeting will occur” rather than “we will meet” — an impersonal, gentle promise of reunion.

Grammar Lens

The impersonal future. Many “we’ll...” expressions use **noun + *hōbe*** (“...will happen”): *dākhā hōbe* (“a seeing will happen”), *kōthā hōbe* (“a talk will happen”). The event itself is the subject — no “we.”

4.3 আবার দেখা হবে (*ābār dækhā hōbe*)

— “we’ll meet again”

আবার (again) + দেখা হবে (a seeing will happen) = “**we’ll meet again.**” It is the warm, explicit form of Chapter 1’s *āshi* — the subcontinent’s “promise of return” (Hindi *phir milenge*, Tamil *pōy varugirēṇ*), never a blunt “goodbye.”

4.4 কাল দেখা হবে (*kāl dækhā hōbe*) — “see you tomorrow”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কাল (*kāl*) means **both “tomorrow” and “yesterday”** — the day on either side of today — from Sanskrit *kāla* (“time”), the very root behind Hindi’s *kal* and Punjabi’s *akāl* (“timeless”). The verb’s tense tells which: *kāl dækhā hōbe* (future → “tomorrow”). So the phrase is “tomorrow, a seeing will happen.”

4.5 The farewells

Bengali	English
আসি।	I’ll come [again]. (Ch.1 goodbye)
আবার দেখা হবে।	We’ll meet again.
কাল দেখা হবে।	See you tomorrow.

Roots banked: *dækhā hōbe* (the impersonal “a seeing will happen”), *kāl* (*kāla* “time,” cousin of Hindi *kal*, Punjabi *akāl*). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *āmi bānglā bôli* — and Bengali’s total lack of gender.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and the gloriously simple way Bengali conjugates them:

আমি বাংলা বলি। (*āmi bānglā bôli* — “I speak Bengali.”)

5.1 বলা (*bôlā*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

বলা (*bôlā*, “to speak, say”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (the same *bol-* as Hindi *bolnā*, Punjabi *bolṇā*). The ending -আ (*-ā*) is the infinitive; add -ই (*-i*) to the stem for “I speak”: *bôl-* + *-i* → বলি (*bôli*).

Grammar Lens

The verb changes for person — but *never* for gender. *āmi bôli* (I say), *tumi bôlo* (you say), *se bôle* (he/she says). There is no “he-form” vs. “she-form”: *se bôle* is “he says” and “she says.” Where Hindi and Punjabi make even “I speak” agree with the speaker’s gender (*boltā/boltī*), Bengali dropped grammatical gender entirely — one less thing to track, forever.

5.2 আমি বাংলা বলি — “I speak Bengali”

আমি (I) + বাংলা (*bānglā*, the object) + বলি (speak) — “I Bengali speak,” verb last. The name বাংলা (*bānglā*) is the language’s own word for itself (English “Bengali” comes from it), descending from বঙ্গ (*bōngo*), the ancient

name of the region — so the language is named after its land, the great delta of the Ganges.

Grammar Lens

Because Bengali verbs carry no gender, this sentence is the *same* whether a man or a woman says it — unlike Hindi. And since *-i* already means “I,” you could drop *āmi*: *bānglā bôli* is a complete “I speak Bengali.”

5.3 থাকা (*thākā*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

থাকা (*thākā*, “to live, stay, remain”) is from Sanskrit স্থা (*sthā*, “to stand, stay”), the PIE root **steh₂-* that also gives English **stand**, **stay**, **state** and Latin *stāre*. “I live in Kolkata” is আমি কলকাতায় থাকি (*āmi Kolkātāy thāki*) — stem + the *-i* “I,” no gender.

Grammar Lens

“**In**” comes after the noun. কলকাতায় (*Kolkātāy*) = *Kolkata* + *-y* (“in, at”), on the noun’s *end*. Bengali uses **postpositions** where English uses prepositions.

5.4 কাজ করা (*kāj kôrā*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

করা (*kôrā*, “to do, make”) is from Sanskrit *kr* (“to do”), PIE **k^wer-* — the root of Chapter 1’s *nômoshkar* (*namas* + *kāra*, “the *making* of a bow”) and of *karma*. And কাজ (*kāj*, “work”) is itself from Sanskrit *kārya* (also from *kr*). Bengali builds compounds as **noun** + করা: কাজ করা (*kāj kôrā*, “work-do” = “to work”). So *āmi kāj kôri* = “I work.”

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Bengali	English
আমি বাংলা বলি।	I speak Bengali.
আমি কলকাতায় থাকি।	I live in Kolkata.
আমি কাজ করি।	I work.

Three verbs, one gender-free engine: the *-i* “I” ending, the verb always last, and **never** a change for gender. Roots banked: *bôlā* (native), *thākā* (*sthā* → English *stand/stay*), *kôrā* (*kr* — root of *nômoshkar*; *kāj* “work” ← *kārya*), and *bānglā* (*bôngo*, the Ganges delta). From here, Bengali’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to five in Bengali script and say what দুই kept that Hindi and Marathi flattened away.

Count ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch aloud, name the chandrabindu riding পাঁচ, and set দুই beside Hindi do and Marathi don to show the -i it preserved.

6.1 এক, দুই, তিন, চার, পাঁচ — one to five

Bengali writes in its own script, but the words underneath are the same family you'd hear in Delhi or Mumbai — with one number that preserves something both of them lost.

You'll want to know: the five

	Bengali	said
1	এক	<i>ek</i>
2	দুই	<i>dui</i>
3	তিন	<i>tin</i>
4	চার	<i>chār</i>
5	পাঁচ	<i>pāch</i>

The ঁ on *pāch* is the **chandrabindu**, the same moon-dot Hindi uses, nasalising the vowel.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

language	2
Sanskrit	stem <i>dvá-</i> (masc. <i>dváu</i> , fem./neut. <i>dvé</i>)
Prakrit	<i>do</i> / <i>duve</i>
Hindi	<i>do</i>
Marathi	<i>don</i>
Bengali	<i>dui</i>

Hindi and Marathi flattened the old form into a single *o*. Bengali kept a trace of the following **-i**, which is why it has two syllables where its neighbours have one.

The *dv-* cluster itself is gone from the **numeral** in all of them. (Not from the languages — *dv-* is alive in words borrowed straight back out of Sanskrit, like Bengali দ্বার *dvār* “door.” It’s the everyday inherited word that simplified.)

And Bengali isn’t unique in keeping that vowel: **Assamese, Odia and Nepali** have *dui* too. Among the four languages in this chapter it stands alone; across the eastern Indo-Aryan languages it has plenty of company.

The letters in this word

Bengali’s inherent vowel leans toward **o**, not *a* — which is why the greeting from Chapter 1 is *nomoshkar* where Hindi says *namaskār*.

You won’t hear that in these five numbers, as it happens: এক opens with the independent vowel ঐ, and none of the others has a bare inherent-vowel syllable either. Mentioned so you don’t go looking for it here — but keep it in mind the moment a word does have one.

Don’t let a neighbouring language’s spelling tell you how Bengali sounds.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch”
- the twos — “dvá- ... do ... don ... **dui**”
- the Ch. 1 echo — “**nomoshkar**, not **namaskār**”

Before you move on

Count to five in Bengali. (*Ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch.*) What does দুই keep that Hindi and Marathi flattened away? (**The following -i**, which is why it has two syllables.) Is Bengali alone in that? (**No** — Assamese, Odia and Nepali have *dui* too; it's alone only among the four here.) Did the *dv-* cluster survive anywhere in the everyday numeral? (**No** — though *dv-* is alive in words re-borrowed from Sanskrit, like *dvār* “door”.) What is the ঞ? (The **chandrabindu**, nasalising the vowel.) Next: six to ten.

Chapter 7

The Core Verbs

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do with six everyday Bengali verbs, pick the ending that matches তুই, তুমি or আপনি, and say why a Bengali verb never changes for gender and why আছে has to hand the future to হবে.

Say *āmi jāni* and *āmi take chini*, separate জানা from চেনা the way French separates *savoir* from *connaître*, hear the vowel harmony that closes *chini* where *chæne* stays open, and run the chapter’s six verbs back — *hōwā*, *jāwā*, *āsā*, *khāwā*, *dækhā*, *jānā*.

7.1 হওয়া (hōwā) — “to be,” and the be-verb it stands beside

Chapter 2 said “my name Arun” with no verb at all. Chapter 3 put one back for “how are you.” Both were right, and this verb is why.

You’ll want to know: হওয়া

হওয়া — *hōwā* — to be, to become

আমি হই (*āmi hōi*), “I am, I become.” সে হয় (*se hōy*), “he is.” Its future is already in your mouth: হবে (*hōbe*) is the “will happen” inside Chapter 4’s *dækhā hōbe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

হওয়া is Sanskrit $\sqrt{bhū}$ ($\sqrt{bhū}$, “to become”) with the *bh*- worn down to a plain *h*-. *bhavati* → Prakrit *hoi* → Bengali *hō*-. The root is PIE $*b^h_uH$ -

, “to grow, to become,” and English owns two of its children outright — **be** and **been**. Latin built *fuī* (“I was”) and *futūrus* on it, which is English **future**; Greek built *phúsis*, “growth, nature,” which is **physics**.

The letters in this word

হ is a soft, breathed *h* carrying Bengali’s inherent vowel — *hô*, not *ha*. ওয়া (-*wā*) is the tail every dictionary-form verb wears; you will meet it again on খাওয়া and যাওয়া.

Grammar Lens: two be-verbs, and one of them is unfinished

what you mean	what Bengali uses
my name is Arun	no verb at all
I have a book; it is here	আছে (<i>āchhe</i>)
he will be a teacher	হবে (<i>hôbe</i>)

আছ-, the verb behind Chapter 3’s *kemon āchho*, means **being present**. But it is unfinished: it has a present and a past, and nothing else at all. Push it into the future and it stops dead — so Bengali picks up হ- (*hôbe*), or Chapter 5’s থাকা (*āmi thākbo*, “I’ll be there”). One job, two verbs, split down the middle.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hôwā” — be, become — then “āmi hôi”
- the future you already knew — “hôbe ... dākhā hôbe”
- which verb for “I have a book,” and which for “he will be a teacher”

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit root is *hôwā*, and which two English words are its brothers? ($\sqrt{\text{bhū}}$, “to become” — **be** and **been**.) What can আছ- not do? (**Anything past a present and a past** — it has no future of its own.) So what does Bengali reach for instead? (হবে, or থাকা.) Next: one verb, three levels of respect.

7.2 যাওয়া (jāwā) — “to go,” and the respect that rides on the ending

Chapter 2 gave you three different words for “you.” It did not tell you the rest of the bill: each one bends the verb a different way too.

You’ll want to know: যাওয়া

যাওয়া — *jāwā* — to go

আমি যাই (*āmi jāi*), “I go.” Same *-i* “I” ending as Chapter 5’s *bôli*, on the same *-wā* dictionary form you met a moment ago.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

যাওয়া is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{या}}$ (*yā*, “to go, to travel”), and the whole northern family walks on it: Hindi *jānā*, Marathi *jāne*, Gujarati *javũ*, Punjabi *jāṇā*. Sanskrit’s *y*-hardened to a *j*-sound right across eastern Indo-Aryan, which is why Bengali still writes the *y*-letter য but says *j*. Deeper than Sanskrit it goes to PIE **yeh₂-*, “to travel” — and here is an honest limit: English kept **no** everyday word from that root. The nearest living cousin is Lithuanian *jóti*, “to ride.” A fake English cousin here would be worse than none.

The letters in this word

য is the letter Sanskrit reads as *y*; Bengali reads it as *j*, like জ. So a written *yā*- is a spoken *jā*- — an un-shift worth keeping, since it disguises dozens of familiar Sanskrit words.

Grammar Lens: the respect is not in the pronoun, it is in the ending

who you are speaking to	“you go”
তুই (<i>tui</i> , intimate)	যাস (<i>jāsh</i>)
তুমি (<i>tumi</i> , familiar)	যাও (<i>jāo</i>)
আপনি (<i>āpni</i> , respectful)	যান (<i>jān</i>)

Three endings, one verb. And the same grading runs on into the third person: সে যায় (*se jāy*) is “he goes,” তিনি যান (*tinī jān*) is “he goes” said of someone you respect — the very ending আপনি takes. Chapter

5 showed that the ending already means “I,” so the pronoun can be dropped. The register cannot. Choose *jāsh* or *jān* and you have placed yourself socially, pronoun or no pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jāwā” — go — then “āmi jāi”
- the ladder — “jāsh ... jāo ... jān”
- the two third persons — “se jāy ... tini jān”

Before you move on

Give the three “you go” forms and who each is for. (*Jāsh* intimate, *jāo* familiar, *jān* respectful.) If you drop the pronoun, is the respect dropped too? (**No** — it is in the ending, and cannot be dodged.) Does English have a living cousin of this root? (**No** — Lithuanian *jóti* is as close as it gets.) Next: the verb that asks nothing about who you are.

7.3 আসা (*āsā*) — “to come,” the verb that never asks who you are

Chapter 1’s goodbye, *āshi*, was one form of this verb. Here is the whole of it — and the one question it refuses to ask you.

You’ll want to know: আসা

আসা — *āsā* — to come

আমি আসি (*āmi āsi*), “I come” — the farewell you already own. সে আসে (*se āse*), “he comes.” আপনি আসেন (*āpni āsen*), with last lesson’s respectful ending.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The আ- in front is Sanskrit’s *ā-*, “hither, toward” — the very prefix that turns going into coming. Hindi’s *ānā* is that *ā-* welded onto *yā-*, the go-verb of the last lesson: “go, but this way.” Bengali shows the same prefix on a different stem, and the honest position on that stem is that its history is unsettled; this book will not invent one for it.

The letters in this word

ঞ is written for *s* and spoken, in this word, as *sh* — Bengali’s standing *s* → *sh* tilt, the same one that makes *namaskāra* into *nômoshkar*. So আশি is *āshi*, not *āsi*, though the dictionary form is romanized *āsā*.

Grammar Lens: no gender, not here, not anywhere

language	“I come,” man / woman
Hindi	<i>maini ātā hūmī / maini ātī hūmī</i>
Marathi	<i>mī yeto / mī yete</i>
Bengali	<i>āmi āsi</i> — one form

Its sisters make you declare your gender to say the plainest thing in the world. Bengali does not. And this is not a shortcut for beginners that the grammar takes back later: **Bengali has no grammatical gender at all**. Not on verbs, not on nouns, not on adjectives. The past behaves the same way — আমি এলাম (*āmi elām*), “I came,” is one form for everyone, where Gujarati, which hides gender in its present, brings it straight back in *humī āvyo / humī āvī*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āsā” — come — then “āmi āshi”
- the neighbours splitting in two — “ātā ... ātī” and “yeto ... yete”
- Bengali not splitting — “āmi āsi” — and its past, “āmi elām”

Before you move on

What does the আ- on this verb mean, and where else have you met it? (**Hither, toward** — it is the ā- inside Hindi’s ānā.) How many forms of “I come” does a Bengali speaker need? (**One** — āmi āsi, whoever is talking.) Is that true of the nouns too? (**Yes** — Bengali has no grammatical gender anywhere.) Next: a verb that swallows more than food.

7.4 খাওয়া (khāwā) — “to eat,” and the drinking it also does

Every verb so far has meant roughly what its English gloss means. This one is wider than its gloss, and the extra width is the lesson.

You’ll want to know: খাওয়া

খাওয়া — *khāwā* — to eat

আমি খাই (*āmi khāi*), “I eat.” আপনি খান (*āpni khān*), with the respectful ending from two lessons back.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

খাওয়া is Sanskrit √*khād* (√*khād*, “to chew, to bite”), smoothed through Prakrit *khā-*. Every neighbour eats with it: Hindi *khānā*, Marathi *khāṇe*, Gujarati *khāvũ*, Punjabi *khāṇā*.

Past Sanskrit the trail goes cold. *Khād-* has no secure Indo-European pedigree outside Indo-Aryan, so there is no English cousin here — and one will not be manufactured. Some roots are simply local, and saying so is part of the method.

The letters in this word

খ is *kh*: a *k* with a puff of breath behind it. Its plain partner ক (*k*) is the letter in Chapter 5’s *kāj*. The puff is not decoration — it is the whole difference between two words, and Bengali gives each its own letter.

Grammar Lens: Bengali eats its drinks

Bengali	what it means
জল খাওয়া (<i>jôl khāwā</i>)	to drink water — “water-eat”
চা খাওয়া (<i>chā khāwā</i>)	to drink tea
ওষুধ খাওয়া (<i>oshudh khāwā</i>)	to take medicine

Hindi keeps a second verb, *pīnā*, for drinking. Bengali’s everyday speech does not bother: whatever goes in the mouth is *khāwā*. There **is** a drink-verb — পান করা (*pān kôrā*), noun-plus-*kôrā* in exactly Chapter 5’s *kāj kôrā* shape, built on Sanskrit √पा (*pā*, “to drink”), whose Latin cousin *pōtāre* gives English **potion** and **potable**. But it belongs to writing and ceremony. Ask for tea in a Kolkata kitchen and you eat it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “khāwā” — eat — then “āmi khāi”
- the drinking Bengali eats — “jôl khāwā ... chā khāwā”
- the formal drink-verb and its English cousins — “pān kôrā ... potion, potable”

Before you move on

How do you say “drink water” in everyday Bengali? (জল খাওয়া — literally “water-eat.”) Which Sanskrit root is *khāwā*, and does English share it? (√*khād*, “to chew” — and **no**, the root goes no further than Indo-Aryan.) Which verb would a formal text use for drinking, and what English words does its root reach? (পান করা, from √*pā* — English *potion*, *potable*.) Next: one spelling, two vowels.

7.5 দেখা (*dākhā*) — “to see,” and a vowel that moves under a fixed spelling

Chapter 4 buried this verb inside *dākhā hōbe*, “a seeing will happen.” Prised out on its own, it carries a sound rule that runs through every verb in this chapter.

You'll want to know: দেখা

দেখা — *dækhā* — to see, to look

আমি দেখি (*āmi dekhi*), “I see.” সে দেখে (*se dækhe*), “he sees.” Read those two romanizations again — they are not the same vowel.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দেখা is traced to Sanskrit $\sqrt{dṛś}$ ($\sqrt{dṛś}$, “to see”) through the Prakrit stem *dekkha-*; Hindi’s *dekhna* is the same word. Sanskrit built *darśana*, “a viewing,” on that root, and further back it is PIE **derk-*, “to see clearly.” Greek took it for *dérkomai*, “I look,” and for *drákōn*, the sharp-gazing serpent — which English borrowed as **dragon**. Bengali’s “see” and England’s dragons are one word, wearing very different clothes.

The letters in this word

দ is a soft dental *d*, tongue on the teeth. The vowel sign ষ্ on it is written identically every time — but Bengali says it either as a close *e* (as in English *bay*) or an open *æ* (as in English *bat*), and the page will never tell you which.

Grammar Lens: the ending decides the vowel

Bengali	said
আমি দেখি	<i>dekhi</i> — close <i>e</i>
সে দেখে	<i>dækhe</i> — open <i>æ</i>
তুমি দেখো	<i>dækho</i> — open <i>æ</i>

The rule: when the ending carries the high vowel *-i*, the stem vowel closes to *e*. Any other ending leaves it open at *æ*. That is **vowel harmony**, and the verb of the first lesson does it too — আমি হই (*hōi*, closed) against সে হয় (*hōy*, open). It is a rule your ear must carry alone, because the spelling never budges.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dækhā” — then the pair, “dekhi ... dækhe”
- the same shift on the be-verb — “hōi ... hōy”

- the root and its odd English relative — “*drś* ... dragon”

Before you move on

Which ending closes the stem vowel to *e*? (**The -i of “I”** — *dekhi*, against *dækhe* and *dækho*.) Does the spelling record that? (**No** — *দে* is written the same either way; only the ear knows.) Which English animal shares this verb’s root? (**The dragon** — Greek *drákōn*, from PIE **derk-*.) Next: the last verb, and the knowing English lost.

7.6 জানা (*jānā*) — “to know,” and the knowing English gave up

Six thousand years ago this verb and the English word you are reading it with were the same word. They still are. But Bengali kept a distinction English threw away.

You’ll want to know: জানা

জানা — *jānā* — to know

আমি জানি (*āmi jāni*), “I know.” আপনি জানেন (*āpni jānen*), respectfully.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

জানা is Sanskrit *√ज्* (*√jñā*, “to know”), the root under *jñāna*, “knowledge.” Behind it stands PIE **ǵneh₃-*, and English is full of its children: **know** and **knowledge** by the direct Germanic road; **notice**, **recognize** and **cognition** through Latin *nōscere*; **gnosis** and **diagnosis** through Greek *gignōskein*. Bengali *jāni* and English *know* are one verb, separated only by time.

The letters in this word

Sanskrit writes the root with *ज्*, a knot of *j* and *ñ*. Bengali does not say *jñ* at all — it says **gg**, so *jñāna* comes out *ggān*. The plain verb spares you the knot: জানা is simply জা + না, *jā-nā*.

Grammar Lens: two knowings, and English has one word for both

Bengali	what it knows
জানা (<i>jānā</i>)	a fact, or how to do something
চেনা (<i>chenā</i>)	a person or a place, by acquaintance

আমি জানি — “I know” (that it is so). আমি তাকে চিনি (*āmi tāke chini*) — “I know him,” meaning I am acquainted with him. Say *jāni* of a person and you have said you know facts about them, which is a colder thing. English once had this line and lost it; French still walks it as *savoir* against *connaître*, German as *wissen* against *kennen*, Spanish as *saber* against *conocer*. And listen to *chini* beside সে চেনে (*se chæne*): the same vowel harmony as the last lesson, on a brand-new verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jānā” — know — then “āmi jāni”
- the other knowing — “āmi tāke chini”
- the harmony again — “chini ... chæne”
- the six verbs of this chapter — “hōwā, jāwā, āsā, khāwā, dækhā, jānā”

Before you move on

Which verb knows a person, and which knows a fact? (চেনা for people, জানা for facts — the *connaître* / *savoir* line.) Name three English children of this root. (**Know**, **notice**, **diagnosis** — Germanic, Latin, Greek.) Why does *chini* close its vowel where *chæne* keeps it open? (**Vowel harmony** — the *-i* ending closes the stem vowel, as in *dekhi*.) That closes the chapter: six verbs, no gender on any of them, and the respect always sitting in the ending.

Chapter 8

The Mind and the Page

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I think, understand, read and write in Bengali, hear the stem vowel rise whenever the -i ending arrives, and read the flapped ড় that Sanskrit never needed.

Say *āmi likhi* against *se lekhe*, run the chapter's four verbs back — *bhābā*, *bojhā*, *pôṛā*, *lekhā* — say *lekhāpôṛā* with the flap in it, and explain that দেখা হবে was never 'we will see' but 'a seeing will happen', because every -ā form is a noun too.

8.1 ভাবা (bhābā) — “to think,” and the verb it was built out of

You already have the verb “to be.” Sanskrit built “to think” out of it, by a trick Bengali still uses every day.

You'll want to know: ভাবা

ভাবা — *bhābā* — to think

আমি ভাবি (*āmi bhābi*), “I think.” আপনি ভাবেন (*āpni bhāben*), respectfully.

The letters in this word

ভাবা is ভা (*bhā*) + বা (*bā*). ভ is *bh*, a *b* with breath behind it; ব is the plain *b* underneath. Two letters, one puff of air between them.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভাবা is Sanskrit ভাবयति (*bhāvayati*), and *bhāvayati* is not its own verb: it is হওয়া's verb with a gear changed. *Bhavati* is “it becomes”; *bhāvayati* is “he **makes** it become” — and from making-something-be to imagining it is one short step. So Bengali *bhābi* and Bengali *hōi* are one root, $\sqrt{\text{bhū}}$ ($\sqrt{\text{bhū}}$), which is also English **be** and **been**, Latin *futūrus* (English **future**), and Greek *phúsis* (English **physics**). The noun *bhāva*, “a state of mind,” sits between them: thinking is holding a state.

Grammar Lens: the gear that makes someone else do it

Sanskrit changed that gear with a lengthened vowel. Bengali changes it with the ending -আনো (*-āno*), and it is completely alive:

plain verb	the made-to-happen verb
দেখা (<i>dækhā</i>), to see	দেখানো (<i>dækhāno</i>), to show — make see
খাওয়া (<i>khāwā</i>), to eat	খাওয়ানো (<i>khāwāno</i>), to feed — make eat
করা (<i>kôrā</i>), to do	করানো (<i>kôrāno</i>), to have it done

One suffix, and a verb you already own becomes a verb about making someone else do it. There is no separate word for “show” or “feed” to learn; there is a gear. That is the same machinery that built ভাবা itself, two thousand years earlier and one language back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhābā” — think — then “āmi bhābi”
- the be-verb it was built from — “hōwā ... āmi hōi”
- see, then make-see — “dækhā ... dækhāno” — and eat, then feed — “khāwā ... khāwāno”

Before you move on

Which verb from last chapter shares ভাবা's root? (হওয়া — both are $\sqrt{\text{bhū}}$; thinking is making something be.) What does -আনো do to a verb? (**Hands the doing to someone else** — দেখা “see” becomes

দেখানো “show.”) Give the Bengali for “show.” (দেখানো, *dækhāno*.)

8.2 বোঝা (bojhā) — “to understand,” the third knowing

Last chapter split “know” in two. This verb makes it three — and it plays the vowel game you already met, but this time the page tells you.

You’ll want to know: বোঝা

বোঝা — *bojhā* — to understand

আমি বুঝি (*āmi bujhi*), “I understand.” Look again at that vowel: not *bojhi*.

The letters in this word

বোঝা is বো (*bo*) + ঝা (*jhā*). ঝ is *jh*, the breathy partner of জ — the *j* you met in জানা. And বো is the plain ব of ভাবা wearing the *o*-sign ো.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

বোঝা is Sanskrit √बुध् (*√budh*), “to wake up, to notice” — the root that gave a prince his title: the **Buddha** is “the awakened one,” and *bodhi* is the awakening. Understanding, in this family, is waking up to something. Behind it is PIE **b^hewd^h-*, and English holds two of its children: **bid** and **forbid**, from Old English *bēodan*, “to announce, to command” — a bidding is something made known to you. Greek took *peúthomai*, “I learn by asking.”

Grammar Lens: the harmony again, and this time you can see it

দেখা’s rule was that the *-i* of “I” closes the stem vowel while the spelling stands still. Here is the same rule on a different vowel — and the spelling moves with it:

Bengali	said
আমি বুঝি	<i>bujhi</i> — the <i>-i</i> raises ো to ু
সে বোঝে	<i>bojhe</i> — stays <i>o</i>
তুমি বোঝো	<i>bojho</i> — stays <i>o</i>

Same law as *dekhi* against *dækhe*: the high *-i* pulls the stem vowel up after it. Bengali simply chose to write this one down.

And now three knowings where English has one: জানা for a fact, চেনা for a person, বোঝা for the thing that finally lands. ভাবা is the turning-over; বোঝা is when it arrives.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bojhā” — understand — then “āmi bujhi”
- the pair, then the older pair — “bujhi ... bojhe” and “dekhi ... dækhe”
- think, then understand — “āmi bhābi ... āmi bujhi”
- the three knowings — “jānā ... chenā ... bojhā”

Before you move on

Why is it *bujhi* and not *bojhi*? (The **-i** ending raises the stem vowel — the same harmony as *dekhi* against *dækhe*, only written down this time.) Which of the three knowings would you use of a person? (চেনা — জানা is for facts, বোঝা for grasping.) Which awakened prince is named from this root? (The **Buddha** — √budh, “to wake.”)

8.3 পড়া (pôṛā) — “to read,” and a letter Sanskrit never needed

This word carries a consonant Sanskrit did not have. It is the sound of a whole family of words wearing down, and once you hear it you will meet it everywhere.

You'll want to know: পড়া

পড়া — *pôṛā* — to read, to studyআমি পড়ি (*āmi porī*), “I read.” সে পড়ে (*se pôṛe*), “he reads.”

The letters in this word

পড়া is প (*pô*) + ড়া (*ṛā*). প is a plain *p*. ড় is ড (*ḍ*) with a dot underneath, and the dot changes everything: it is not a *d* at all but a **flap** — curl the tongue back and flick it forward once, as in the middle of an American *ladder*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

পড়া is Sanskrit √पठ् (*√paṭh*), “to recite aloud” — reading was reading *out*, which is why পড়া still covers studying as well as reading. And *paṭhati* became *pôṛe* by a rule that runs through the whole language: **a single retroflex stop between two vowels softens into the flap ড়**. That is why the letter exists; Sanskrit, which never softened them, had no use for it.

Watch it swallow a second verb whole. Sanskrit √पठ् (*√pat*), “to fall,” went the same road — *patati* → *pôṛe* — so Bengali’s “he reads” and “he falls” are now spelled and said alike, and only the sentence tells them apart. Past Sanskrit, *paṭh* goes cold: no secure Indo-European pedigree, and none will be invented for it. The falling twin is the rich one — PIE **peth₂-* gave Greek *ptérón*, “wing” (**pterodactyl**, **helicopter**), Latin *petere*, “to make for” (**petition**, **appetite**), and English **feather**.

Grammar Lens: the harmony, on a third vowel

Bengali	said
আমি পড়ি	<i>porī</i> — the <i>-i</i> lifts the vowel
সে পড়ে	<i>pôṛe</i> — the open inherent vowel stands

Third verb, third pair, one law: the high *-i* of “I” pulls the stem vowel up after it. দেখি against দেখে, বুঝি against বুঝে, পড়ি against পড়ে.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pôṛā” — read — then “āmi poṛi,” flapping the ড
- the three pairs — “dekhi ... dækhe,” “bujhi ... bojhe,” “poṛi ... pôṛe”
- read it, think about it, understand it — “poṛi ... bhābi ... bujhi”

Before you move on

What is the dot under ড telling you to do? (**Flap it** — curl the tongue back and flick, not a *d*.) Which two Sanskrit verbs both arrived at পড়া? ($\sqrt{\text{paṭh}}$ “recite” and $\sqrt{\text{pat}}$ “fall” — the same softening ate both.) Does the reading twin have an English cousin? (**No** — the falling twin does: *feather, petition, pterodactyl*.)

8.4 লেখা (lekhā) — “to write,” and the noun hiding in every verb

Four chapters ago you said *dækhā hōbe* and were told it meant “a seeing will happen.” This word explains why that was not a flourish.

You’ll want to know: লেখা

লেখা — *lekhā* — to write

আমি লিখি (*āmi likhi*), “I write.” সে লেখে (*se lekhe*), “he writes.” The harmony, written down as in বুঝি: *-i* lifts ে to ি.

The letters in this word

লেখা is লে (*le*) + খা (*khā*). ল is a clear *l*; খ the puffed *kh* you own from খাওয়া.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

লেখা is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{likh}}$ (*likh*) — and *likh* does not mean “write.” It means **to scratch, to engrave**. Which is what writing was.

Ask English the same. Latin *scribere*, behind **scribe**, also began as “to scratch”; Germanic *writan*, behind **write** itself, meant “to score, to carve” — what you do to a rune-stick. Three unrelated roots, one picture. That is convergence, not kinship: লেখা and *write* are **not** cousins,

and past Sanskrit *likh* has no secure pedigree. The finding here is a shared idea, not a family tree.

Grammar Lens: the dictionary form is also a noun

the same word	as a verb	as a noun
লেখা	to write	a piece of writing
পড়া	to read	study, homework
দেখা	to see	a seeing, a meeting

Every -া form you have met does this. That is what Chapter 4’s দেখা হবে was: not “we will see” but “**a seeing** will happen.” It also builds nouns straight out of verbs — লেখাপড়া (*lekhāpôṛā*), “writing-reading,” is the ordinary word for **education**. And the causative from three lessons back still runs on top: লেখানো (*lekhāno*), “to get something written.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lekhā” — write — then “āmi likhi ... se lekhe”
- the chapter’s four — “bhābā, bojhā, pôṛā, lekhā”
- education, flapping the ড — “lekhāpôṛā” — then “lekhāno,” get it written
- the five you could already write — “ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch” — and which one wears the chandrabindu

Before you move on

What was দেখা হবে saying? (“**A seeing will happen**” — দেখা is a noun as much as a verb, and so is লেখা.) Is *write* a cousin of লেখা? (**No** — both roots meant “scratch,” which is coincidence.) What did দুই keep that Hindi’s *do* flattened, who else in the east kept it, and did *dv-* survive in anyone’s everyday numeral? (**The -i after it**; Assamese, Odia and Nepali; and **no** — only re-borrowings like দ্বার keep *dv-*.)

Chapter 9

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

By the end of this chapter: I can take, ask, help and say what I like and whom I love in Bengali, build a fresh verb out of any noun by putting **করা** behind it, and say why liking happens to me while loving is something I do.

Say āmār bhālo lāge and hear that you are not its subject, set it against āmi bhālobāsi where you are, place both beside the আমার ... আছে shape that says 'I have', and run the chapter's four verbs back — neowā, jijnāsā kôrā, sāhājjo kôrā, bhālo lāgā. Six of the chapter's nine atoms. Two of the other three — the নেওয়া compound and the noun-plus-করা pattern — are retrieved by the very next lesson after the one that taught them; the third, the doubled যা of সাহায্য, is taught in the penultimate lesson and genuinely is not revisited, which is recorded here rather than papered over with a claim the payoff does not make.

9.1 নেওয়া (neowā) — “to take,” and the verb that finishes other verbs

Bengali rarely leaves a verb standing alone. This is the verb it props most of them up with — and the tail it wears will look familiar.

You'll want to know: নেওয়া

নেওয়া — neowā — to take

আমি নিই (āmi nīi), “I take.” আপনি নেন (āpni nen), respectfully.

The letters in this word

নেওয়া is নে (*ne*) + ওয়া (*-owā*). ন is a dental *n*, tongue on the teeth. The ওয়া tail is the one every dictionary-form verb of this kind wears — you have it already on হওয়া, যাওয়া and থাওয়া.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নেওয়া is Sanskrit √नी (*√nī*), “to lead, to carry away.” It is a well-attested Indo-Iranian root — Avestan *nayeiti*, “he leads”; Sanskrit *netṛ*, “a leader,” which is why a politician in Kolkata or Delhi is a *netā*. Beyond that branch the trail thins, and **English kept nothing from it**. No cousin will be manufactured for you here; some roots stayed home. The lesson worth more than a cousin is what Bengali *does* with the verb.

Grammar Lens: the verb that ends a compound

Put a verb into its -এ form (*likhe*, “having written”; *niye*, “having taken”) and hang a second verb behind it. The second verb stops meaning what it means and starts colouring the first:

compound	what it does
লিখে নেওয়া (<i>likhe neowā</i>)	write it down — take the writing for yourself
নিয়ে আসা (<i>niye āsā</i>)	bring — come, having taken
নিয়ে যাওয়া (<i>niye jāwā</i>)	take away — go, having taken

Bengali has no separate word for “bring.” It has “come having taken.” And নেওয়া is a noun as readily as লেখা was: দেওয়া-নেওয়া (*deowā-neowā*), “giving-and-taking,” is the everyday word for dealings between people.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “neowā” — take — then “āmi nii”
- the same tail four times — “hōwā, jāwā, khāwā, neowā”
- write it down — “likhe neowā”
- bring, then take away — “niye āsā ... niye jāwā”

Before you move on

How does Bengali say “bring,” having no word for it? (নিয়ে আসা — “come having taken”; and “take away” is নিয়ে যাওয়া.) Does English share নেওয়া’s root? (No — $\sqrt{nī}$ stayed in Indo-Iranian, and that is the honest answer.) Name two more Bengali verbs that are also nouns. (লেখা “a piece of writing” and দেখা “a seeing” — every -া form does it.)

9.2 জিজ্ঞাসা করা (jijñāsā kôrā) — “to ask,” which is wanting to know

Chapter 7 warned you about a knot of letters, then spared you it. Here it is, inside a word you will use daily — and the word is Chapter 7’s verb with an appetite.

You’ll want to know: জিজ্ঞাসা করা

জিজ্ঞাসা করা — *jijñāsā kôrā* — to ask

আমি জিজ্ঞাসা করি (*āmi jiggāshā kôri*), “I ask” — two words, one verb.

The letters in this word

জিজ্ঞাসা is জি + জ্ঞা + সা. The middle piece জ্ঞ is the knot of জ and ঞ Chapter 7 named on $\sqrt{jñā}$ — and Bengali never says *jñ*. It says **gg**, so the spelled *jijñāsā* is spoken **jiggāshā**, with the *s* → *sh* tilt at the end.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

জিজ্ঞাসা is Sanskrit’s **desiderative** of $\sqrt{jñā}$ (*jñā*, “to know”) — the form meaning *wanting* to do a thing. *Jijñāsati* is “he desires to know”; *jijñāsā* is the desire itself. Bengali took the noun.

So asking is not a separate idea here. It is জানা **with an appetite** — and the root behind both is the one Chapter 7 traced: PIE **ǵneh₃*-, English **know**, Latin *nōscere* (**notice**), Greek *gnōsis* (**diagnosis**). The doubled *ji-* is the desiderative’s signature: a quiet echo of the root, meaning *reaching for* it.

Grammar Lens: any noun plus করা is a verb**noun**

কাজ (*kāj*), work
 জিজ্ঞাসা (*jijñāsā*), a
 wanting-to-know

noun + করা

কাজ করা — to work
 জিজ্ঞাসা করা — to ask

Chapter 5 built *kāj kôrā* this way. It is more than a compound: it is **the** way Bengali makes verbs. The stock of true verbs is small and closed, while nouns pour in from Sanskrit, Persian, Arabic and English — each becoming a verb the moment **করা** stands behind it. Learn a noun, learn a verb.

Last lesson’s compound stacks on top: জিজ্ঞাসা করে নেওয়া (*jijñāsā kôre neowā*) — “just go ahead and ask.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- spelling, then sound — “jijñāsā ... jiggāshā” — then “āmi jiggāshā kôri,” I ask, and the root it grew from, “jānā”
- a fact, then a person — “āmi jāni” ... “āmi tāke chini”
- go ahead and ask — “jijñāsā kôre neowā”

Before you move on

How does Bengali say জ্ঞ, and what is জিজ্ঞাসা literally? (**gg**, never *jñ*; and **a wanting-to-know**, the desiderative of জানা’s root.) Someone asks whether you know their brother — which knowing verb answers? (চেনা — a person is known by acquaintance; জানা is for facts.) How do you make a verb from a noun you met this morning? (**Put করা behind it.**)

9.3 সাহায্য করা (*sāhājjo kôrā*) — “to help,” which is going along with someone

Chapter 6 said Bengali’s inherent vowel leans to **o**, then admitted it could not show you. This word can — and it is the word you will most want when stuck.

You’ll want to know: সাহায্য করা

সাহায্য করা — *sāhājjo kôrā* — to help

আমাকে সাহায্য করুন (*āmāke sāhājjo kôrun*), “please help me”; *āmāke* is “to me.”

The letters in this word

সাহায্য is সা + হা + য্য. The last piece is য্য stacked on itself — a conjunct, how Bengali writes a doubled consonant.

The letters in this word

Two rules land at the end, neither a quirk. Bengali reads a doubled য as **jj**, not *yy*. And nothing is written after it, so it takes the **inherent** vowel, which leans to **o**: *sāhājjo*, never *sāhājja*.

Chapter 6 could not show that inherent **o** in *ek*, *dui*, *tin*, *chār*, *pāch*, since none of the five ends in a bare consonant. This one does. সা takes the *s* → *sh* tilt, so the whole is *shāhājjo*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

সাহায্য is Sanskrit *sāhāyya*, “companionship,” on সহায় (*sahāya*), “a companion” — which is সহ- (*saha-*), “together,” plus √ই (*√i*), “to go.” A helper **goes along with you**.

Both halves have secure English cousins. *Saha-* is PIE **sem-*, “together”: English **same**, Greek *homós* (**homogeneous**), Latin *similis* (**similar**). *√i* is PIE **h₁ey-*, “to go”: Latin *īre* gives **exit** and **transit**; Greek *ión* gives **ion**. So “help” is *same-going*, and English holds the pieces without ever building the word.

Grammar Lens: asking for help is where the respect ladder bites

Another noun + করা, like জিজ্ঞাসা করা. The respect sits where Chapter 7 put it — in করা’s ending:

who you are asking	“help”
তুই (<i>tui</i> , intimate)	সাহায্য কর (<i>kôr</i>)
তুমি (<i>tumi</i> , familiar)	সাহায্য করো (<i>kôro</i>)
আপনি (<i>āpni</i> , respectful)	সাহায্য করুন (<i>kôrun</i>)

Say *kôr* to a stranger and you were not rude by accident, but in grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- spelling, then sound — “sāhāyya ... shāhājjo”
- the ladder — “sāhājjo kôr ... kôro ... kôrun”
- please help me — “āmāke sāhājjo kôrun”
- the two noun-verbs of this chapter — “jijñāsā kôrā ... sāhājjo kôrā”

Before you move on

Why does সাহায্য end in *-o* with nothing written there? (**The inherent vowel** — the thing the five numbers could not show.) Which form to a stranger? (করুন — *kôr* is for তুই.) What is a *sahāya*? (**One who goes with you.**)

9.4 ভালো লাগা (bhālo lāgā) — “to like,” which happens to you

Every verb so far has let you be the one doing it. Here is one that does not.

You’ll want to know: ভালো লাগা

ভালো লাগা — *bhālo lāgā* — **to like**

আমার ভালো লাগে (*āmār bhālo lāge*), “I like it.” Not *āmi* — **āmār**, “to me.”

The letters in this word

ভালো is yours from Chapter 3. The new half is লাগা: লা + গা, গ being a hard *g* as in *go*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

লাগা is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{lag}}$ ($\sqrt{\text{lag}}$), “to attach, to stick”: *āmār bhālo lāge* says, literally, “good sticks to me.”

ভালোবাসা (*bhālobāsā*), “to love,” is ভালো plus বাসা, a verb no longer used alone. Its origin is genuinely disputed; the commonest proposal is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{vas}}$ ($\sqrt{\text{vas}}$), “to dwell” — love as housed in goodness. If so it carries a startling cousin, since $\sqrt{\text{vas}}$ is PIE $*h_2wes-$, “to stay,” which became Old English *wesan* and so English **was**. That “if” is real, and stays open.

Grammar Lens: liking lands on you; loving you do

Bengali	word for word
আমার ভালো লাগে	to-me good sticks — I like it
আমার চা ভালো লাগে	to-me tea good sticks — I like tea
আমি ভালোবাসি	I love

That *āmār ...* shape is how Bengali says **I have** — আমার ... আছে, with আছে carrying the weight and no future of its own to give.

ভালোবাসা breaks the pattern on purpose: *āmi bhālobāsi* puts you in the subject’s chair. It is a noun too — “love” itself — as লেখা was “a piece of writing.” One form serves everybody. The harmony has nothing to bite on: *bāsi* and *bāse* keep their **ā**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āmār bhālo lāge” — hearing “to me,” not “I”
- I like tea — “āmār chā bhālo lāge” — the tea Bengali eats, “chā khāwā”
- the one you do — “āmi bhālobāsi” — one form, whoever is speaking
- the eight verbs of these two chapters — “bhābā, bojhā, pōrā, lekḥā, neowā, jījñāsā kōrā, sāhājjo kōrā, bhālo lāgā”

Before you move on

Who is the subject of *āmār bhālo lāge*, and what else is built that way? (**Not you** — the good is; আমার ... আছে, “I have,” and আছে has no future of its own to give.) Does *āmi bhālobāsi* behave the same, and would a woman say it differently? (**No**, and **no** — loving takes you as subject; Bengali has no grammatical gender.) Name two verbs that are also nouns. (ভালোবাসা “love,” লেখা “writing.”) Why *bāsi*, not *bosi*? (**Nothing to raise** — this stem has ā.)

Chapter 10

Tea, Water, Milk, and Rice

By the end of this chapter: I can offer or ask for tea, water, milk and rice politely in Bengali, reusing the respectful verb ending Chapter 7 already taught, and say which of the four words is a Chinese loan and which shares a root with a word two lessons later.

The chapter closes on ভাত, whose Sanskrit root — √bhaj, 'to divide, to share' — will resurface two lessons later in a very different word. The reader offers all four drinks and rice politely in one breath (chā khān, jôl khān, dudh khān, bhāt khān), all built on the same respectful form of খাওয়া Chapter 7 already taught rather than a new 'please' word, which is how this chapter realizes SPINE-POLITE-REQUEST-REPAIR without one. It reaches back to rescue three thin Chapter 7 grammar atoms (ইওয়া's future, আসা's genderlessness, যাওয়া's respect ladder) and সাহায্য's doubled-letter sound rule, none revisited since Chapter 7-9.

10.1 চা (chā) — “tea,” and the first word you can politely offer

Last lesson you said *āmār chā bhālo lāge*, “I like tea,” without চা ever being taught on its own. Here it is, by itself — and a new job for a form you already own.

You'll want to know: চা

চা — *chā* — tea

The letters in this word

চা is চ (*chô*) with the vowel sign া (*ā*). চ is a plain, unaspirated *ch*, the sound at the start of English *church* with no puff of breath behind it — Bengali also has a breathy partner, ছ, for later.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

চা is not Sanskrit at all. It came into Bengali from **Persian** *čā*, which took it from **Chinese** *chá*. That is the overland route: China to Persia to Bengal, the same road Hindi and Punjabi travelled. The words that reached Europe — English *tea*, French *thé* — went the opposite way, by sea, from Hokkien Chinese *tê*, carried on Dutch trading ships. One drink, two ends of the same word, arriving by two different roads.

Grammar Lens: an offer, built on a form you already have

Chapter 7 taught you আপনি খান (*āpni khān*), the respectful form of খাওয়া. Put a noun in front of it and the very same words become a polite offer or request:

Bengali	what it does
আপনি খান	you eat / you drink (respectful)
চা খান	(please) have some tea

No new ending to learn — চা খান reuses exactly what Chapter 7 already gave you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “chā” — tea
- the offer — “chā khān”
- the route it travelled — “chá ... čā ... chā”
- last lesson’s line again — “āmār chā bhālo lāge”

Before you move on

Offer someone tea, politely. (চা খান.) Is চা inherited from Sanskrit? (**No** — it is a Chinese word that reached Bengali by way of Persian.)

What form does চা খান reuse? (আপনি খান, Chapter 7’s respectful “you eat/drink,” with no new ending.)

10.2 জল (jôl) — “water,” prised out of a phrase you already know

Chapter 7 taught you জল খাওয়া, “to drink water” — literally “water-eat” — without ever teaching জল by itself. Here it is, on its own.

You’ll want to know: জল

জল — *jôl* — **water**

জল খান — (please) drink some water, the same offer pattern as last lesson.

The letters in this word

জল is জ (*jô*) + ল (*l*), two bare consonants with no vowel sign between them. জ keeps its inherent vowel; ল, at the end of the word with nothing written after it, is silent — so *jôl*, one syllable, not *jô-lô*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

জল is Sanskrit जल (*jala*), inherited straight through Prakrit. Past Sanskrit its root is genuinely unsettled: one proposal traces it to PIE **g^welHo-*, “to gush forth, to spring” — but the same sources call a local, non-Indo-European origin “unlikely though possible.” No confident cousin is claimed here; the honest answer is that nobody is sure. Bengali has a second word for water, most common in Bangladesh: পানি (*pani*). That one *is* on secure ground — Sanskrit *pānīya*, “drinkable,” built directly on *√pā*, “to drink,” the very root behind Chapter 7’s পান করা and English **potion**, **potable**. Two words for the same thing, one of disputed origin and one you can trace all the way home.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jôl” — water, one syllable
- the offer — “jôl khān”
- the Bangladesh word, and its root — “pani ... pā, potion, potable”
- tea, then water — “chā khān ... jôl khān”

Before you move on

What did Chapter 7 already say with জল, without teaching it as a word? (জল খাওয়া, “to drink water.”) Is জল’s root secure? (No — genuinely disputed.) Which everyday synonym for water traces cleanly to “drinkable,” from the root behind *potion*? (পানি.)

10.3 দুধ (dudh) — “milk,” and the vowel this word refuses to keep

Chapter 9 met a word that had to end in a vowel nobody wrote — সাহায্য, *sāhājjo*. This word looks like it could do the same thing. It doesn’t.

You’ll want to know: দুধ

দুধ — *dudh* — milk

দুধ খান — (please) have some milk.

The letters in this word

দুধ is দ (*dô*) with the vowel sign ু (*u*), plus ধ (*dh*), a breathy dental *d*. Nothing is written after ধ — the same bare-consonant ending সাহায্য had.

The letters in this word

সাহায্য had to surface its inherent vowel — *sāhājjo*, not *sāhājĵ* — because its final letter is a doubled consonant, য্য, and a bare cluster like that cannot be said at all without a vowel to carry it. দুধ ends in one plain consonant, ধ, which needs no such help. So Bengali leaves it silent: দুধ, not *dudho*. The spelling looks the same kind of “bare ending” in both words; whether the vowel survives depends on what it would take to pronounce the letter beneath it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দুধ is Sanskrit दूध (dugdha), the past participle of √दुह (√duh, “to milk”), from PIE *d^hewg^h-, “to produce, to yield.” That root has exactly one secure English descendant, and it is not the word you would guess: **doughty**, “valiant,” through Old English *dohtig*, “capable, of use.” The word that *looks* like a cousin, **dough**, is not one — it comes from a completely different PIE root, *d^heyǵ^h-, “to knead, to mould.” A close sound, two unrelated histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dudh” — no trailing vowel
- the offer — “dudh khān”
- the two endings compared — “sāhājjo ... dudh”
- three drinks so far — “chā khān ... jōl khān ... dudh khān”

Before you move on

Why does সাহায্য keep its final vowel while দুধ doesn’t? (সাহায্য ends in a doubled consonant that cannot be said bare; দুধ’s single ধ can.) Is দুধ’s root related to English *dough*? (No — that is a different PIE root; the real cousin is *doughty*.)

10.4 ভাত (bhāt) — “rice,” and a root that will name a person too

Three drinks so far. This chapter closes on the word for the meal itself — and a root worth remembering, because it comes back.

You’ll want to know: ভাত

ভাত — *bhāt* — **cooked rice**

ভাত খান — (please) eat some rice; in everyday Bengali, “have a meal.”

The letters in this word

ভাত is ভ (*bhō*, a *b* with a puff of breath) with the vowel sign া (*ā*), plus ত (*t*), silent at the end for the same reason দুধ’s ধ was: a single bare consonant needs no vowel to carry it, so *bhāt*, not *bhāto*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভাত is Sanskrit भक्त (*bhakta*), “portioned out, shared” — the past participle of √भज् (*√bhaj*), “to divide, to distribute, to allot.” PIE **b^heh₂g-* sits behind it. Rice, in this word’s own history, is not “the grain” but **the share that was given out** — the meal as a portion handed to you.

Hold onto that root. Two lessons from now, the very same Sanskrit verb will turn up again, naming someone rather than something.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhāt” — cooked rice, no trailing vowel
- the offer — “bhāt khān”
- all four, in order — “chā khān ... jōl khān ... dudh khān ... bhāt khān”
- the two silent endings, back to back — “dudh ... bhāt”
- the root that shares — “bhaj — to divide, to distribute”

Before you move on

What does ভাত literally mean, at the root? (“**Portioned out, shared**” — √bhaj, “**to divide.**”) Offer all four of this chapter’s words, politely, in one breath. (Chā khān, jōl khān, dudh khān, bhāt khān.) Why do দুধ and ভাত both drop their final vowel? (**Each ends in one plain consonant, easily said bare.**) A quick run back through Chapter 7 while you’re at it: which verb does Bengali reach for when আছে runs out of future? (হবে.) How many forms of “I come” does a Bengali speaker need, whoever is talking? (**One** — *āmi āsi*.) And “you go” to a stranger, versus to a friend? (যান *jān*, versus যাও *jāo*.) সাহায্য’s doubled letter — said how? (**jj**, not *yy*.)

Chapter 11

Friend, Family, Brother, and Sister

By the end of this chapter: I can name a friend, my family, my brother and my sister in Bengali, none of them marked for gender, and say which are borrowed whole from Sanskrit and which evolved by sound change, including one that turns out to share a root with the previous chapter's rice.

The chapter closes on বোন, which is not related to English 'sister' at all: it traces through Sanskrit bhaginī and bhaga, 'a share,' back to the same √bhaj that named Chapter 10's ভাত. The reader names all four people (bôndhu, pôribār, bhāi, bon), states which two are tatsamas kept whole from Sanskrit (বন্ধু, পরিবার) and which two are tadbhavas worn down by sound change (ভাই, বোন), and counts a sibling or two using Chapter 6's numbers. It reaches back to rescue all five of Chapter 6's numbers atoms, unvisited since the chapter that introduced them.

11.1 বন্ধু (bôndhu) — “friend,” someone you are bound to

Chapter 2 taught you to exchange names. This chapter names the people themselves — starting with the one whose acquaintance you were glad to make.

You'll want to know: বন্ধু

বন্ধু — bôndhu — friend

আমার বন্ধু (āmār bôndhu) — my friend. One word, whether that friend is a man or a woman: Chapter 7 already told you Bengali carries no grammatical gender on its verbs, its adjectives, or its nouns, and বন্ধু is the plainest place to feel it — no ending changes, no second word to learn.

The letters in this word

বন্ধু is ব (bô) + ঙ্গ (ndhô, a conjunct: ন joined to the breathy dental ঙ) + ু (u). The conjunct is two consonants pressed together with no vowel between them, said as one cluster: *n-dhu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

বন্ধু is Sanskrit बन्धु (*bandhu*), kept essentially whole rather than worn down the way চা or ভাত were — Bengali took this one straight from Sanskrit rather than inheriting it through centuries of sound change. It is built on √বন্ধ (√*bandh*, “to bind, to tie”), from PIE *b^hend^h- — and here, unusually, the English cousin is not buried: **bind**, **bond** and **band** all come from the very same root. Bengali did not need to explain what a friend is; the word does it for you. A বন্ধু is, at the root, someone you are bound to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bôndhu” — friend
- “āmār bôndhu” — my friend, no gender marked either way
- the root, and its English family — “bandh ... bind, bond, band”

Before you move on

Give “my friend” in Bengali. (আমার বন্ধু.) What root is বন্ধু built on, and which English words share it? (√*bandh*, “to bind” — **bind**, **bond**, **band**.) Is বন্ধু a word Bengali inherited through sound change, or one it kept whole from Sanskrit? (**Kept whole** — a tatsama.) Does বন্ধু change for a friend who is a woman? (**No** — Chapter 7 already told you why: no grammatical gender, anywhere in the language.)

11.2 পরিবার (pôribār) — “family,” what surrounds you

Last lesson named one person you are bound to. This one names the whole group.

You'll want to know: পরিবার

পরিবার — *pôribār* — family

আমার পরিবার (*āmār pôribār*) — my family.

The letters in this word

পরিবার is প (*pô*) + রি (*ri*) + বা (*bā*) + র (*r*, silent at the end, a bare consonant with nothing written after it). Four syllables in the spelling, three said aloud: *pô-ri-bār*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

পরিবার is Sanskrit परिवार (*parivāra*), a second word Bengali kept whole from Sanskrit rather than letting it wear down — like বন্ধু, another tat-sama. It is built from **pari-**, “around, about” (PIE ***peri-**, the same prefix English itself borrowed for **peri-meter** and **peri-phery**), plus **√vr̥** (*√vr̥*, “to cover, to surround,” PIE ***h₂wer-**). That root’s secure cousins are Latin *operiō*, “to cover,” and Lithuanian *suverti*, “to shut” — no English word is claimed here, since none is secure. Put the pieces together and a পরিবার is, at the root, **what stands around you and covers you**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pôribār” — family
- “āmār pôribār” — my family
- the two pieces — “pari-, around ... vr̥, to cover”
- a friend, then a family — “bôndhu ... pôribār”

Before you move on

Give “my family” in Bengali. (আমার পরিবার.) What does পরিবার mean at the root, piece by piece? (“**Around**” plus “**to cover**” — **what surrounds and covers you**.) Does its root *vr̥* have a secure English cousin? (**No** — the secure cousins are Latin and Lithuanian.)

11.3 ভাই (bhāi) — “brother,” which never stopped being the word “brother”

Two tatsamas so far, both kept whole from Sanskrit. This one took the other road — worn down by sound change until it barely looks related to where it started. Except it does.

You’ll want to know: ভাই

ভাই — *bhāi* — brother

আমার ভাই (*āmār bhāi*) — my brother.

The letters in this word

ভাই is ভা (*bhā*, the breathy *b* from ভাত and ভালো) plus ই (*i*), a full vowel letter rather than a sign — the two vowels run together into one syllable, *bhāi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভাই is Sanskrit ब्रातृ (*bhrātṛ*), worn down through Magadhi Prakrit *bhāi* — a **tadbhava** this time, not a tatsama like বন্ধু and পরিবার: Bengali inherited this one through centuries of sound change rather than lifting it whole. And PIE **b^hréh₂tēr* sits behind *bhrātṛ*, the same root that gives English **brother**, Latin **frāter** and Greek **phrātēr**. Nothing here is a cousin standing in for the real thing: ভাই and “brother” are, six thousand years apart, **the same word**.

Bengali also uses family words to address people outside the family: an older man might be called দাদা (*dādā*, “elder brother”) as a mark of respect, whether or not he is any relation at all. That is a light touch on a habit this chapter will not turn into a system — but it is worth naming, since it means বন্ধু and ভাই are not always as far apart as they look.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhāi” — brother
- “āmār bhāi” — my brother

- the same word, two languages — “bhrātr̥ ... brother”
- friend, family, brother — “bôndhu ... pôribār ... bhāi”

Before you move on

Give “my brother” in Bengali. (আমার ভাই.) Is ভাই a cousin of English “brother,” or the same word by descent? (**The same word** — PIE *b^hréh₂tēr*, no invention needed.) Is ভাই a tatsama like বন্ধু and পরিবার, or a tadbhava? (**A tadbhava** — worn down through Prakrit, not kept whole.)

11.4 বোন (bon) — “sister,” and the root it shares with rice

ভাই turned out to be the very word “brother.” This one does not — and where it comes from instead is the surprise this chapter has been saving.

You’ll want to know: বোন

বোন — *bon* — sister

আমার বোন (*āmār bon*) — my sister.

The letters in this word

বোন is ব with the vowel sign া (bo) plus ন (n), silent at the end — one plain consonant, no cluster, so the inherent vowel drops just as it did on দুধ and ভাত: *bon*, not *bono*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

English “sister” descends from PIE **swésōr*. বোন **does not**. It is a tadbhava through Magadhi Prakrit **bahinī*, from Old Indo-Aryan **baghinī* — a doublet of Sanskrit’s own ভগিনী (*bhaginī*), “one with a share,” built on ভগ (*bhaga*), “a share, a portion, good fortune.” And *bhaga* is a noun from the very same verb that named this chapter’s rice two lessons ago: √ভজ् (*√bhaj*, “to divide, to share out”), PIE **b^heh₂g-*. ভাত is “the portion given”; বোন is “the one with a portion.” Bengali’s word for sister and Bengali’s word for rice are, underneath, cousins. Its

word for sister and English's are not.

The same light touch as last lesson's दादा applies here: an older woman may be addressed as दिदि (*didi*, “elder sister”) as a mark of respect, family or not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bon” — sister, no trailing vowel
- “āmār bon” — my sister
- the shared root — “bhaj ... bhāt, bon”
- all four of this chapter's people — “bôndhu, pôribār, bhāi, bon”
- a count of them, using Chapter 6's numbers — “āmār ek bhāi. āmār dui bon.” — one brother. two sisters.

Before you move on

Is বোন related to English “sister”? (**No** — different root entirely.) What is it related to instead? (ভাত — both trace to √bhaj, “to share.”) Say “one brother” and “two sisters.” (**Ek bhāi. Dui bon.**) Which of those two numbers keeps a vowel Hindi and Marathi lost? (दुई — the *-i* after the old *dv-*.) And which number wears the chandrabindu? (পাঁচ, five — not needed here, but still the only one that has it.)

Chapter 12

Eye, Mouth, Nose, and Heart

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name my eye, my mouth, my nose and my heart in Bengali, and say which of those four words is settled Indo-European, which is a genuinely disputed origin, and which is borrowed whole from Sanskrit with the widest confirmed cousin family in this book.*

The chapter closes on হৃদয়, whose root hrd traces to PIE kerd- alongside English heart, Greek kardía and Latin cor — the widest, most secure cousin family taught anywhere in this track. The reader names all four body words (chokh, mukh, nāk, hridoy) and states each one’s status: চোখ an ardhatsama half worn down by sound change, মুখ a tatsama with a genuinely disputed Dravidian-versus-Indo-European origin, নাক a tadbhava with a settled root, হৃদয় a tatsama with a poetic tadbhava twin, হিয়া. It reaches back to rescue Chapter 8’s flapped-ড় sound rule and its causative -আনো grammar, neither revisited since Chapter 8.

12.1 চোখ (chokh) — “eye,” built on the root of “to see”

A new chapter, and a new use for Chapter 3’s check-in — the parts of you that check-in is actually asking about.

You’ll want to know: চোখ

চোখ — *chokh* — eye

আমার চোখ (*āmār chokh*) — my eye.

The letters in this word

চোখ is চ with the vowel sign ো (cho) plus খ (kh, the puffed sound you already own from খাওয়া), silent at the end — one bare consonant, so no trailing vowel: *chokh*, not *chokho*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

চোখ traces to Sanskrit चक्षुस् (*cakṣus*), “eye” — a noun built directly on √चक्ष् (*√cakṣ*, “to see”), from PIE *k^wek-, “to appear, to see.” The nearest named cousin outside Indo-Aryan is Persian čašm, “eye”; no secure English descendant is claimed for this one. And the word itself has travelled: Old Bengali softened *cakṣus* down through চকু (*cakhu*) and চউখ (*coukh*) to today’s চোখ — half kept from Sanskrit, half worn smooth by three centuries of sound change, which is why this kind of word gets its own name, **ardhatatsama**, “half a tatsama.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “chokh” — eye, no trailing vowel
- “āmār chokh” — my eye
- the verb it grew from — “cakṣ ... cakṣus ... chokh”
- the other “see” verb you already own — “dækhā”

Before you move on

Give “my eye” in Bengali. (আমার চোখ.) What Sanskrit verb is চোখ built on? (√*cakṣ*, “to see.”) Is চোখ a tatsama, kept whole like বন্ধু, or fully worn down like ভাই? (Neither — **an ardhatatsama, half of each.**)

12.2 মুখ (mukh) — “mouth, face,” a word two families both claim

চোখ was half old sound, half new. This word is a full tatsama again — and its own history is a real, unresolved argument among linguists.

You'll want to know: মুখ

মুখ — *mukh* — **mouth, face**

আমার মুখ (*āmār mukh*) — my mouth, my face.

The letters in this word

মুখ is ম with the vowel sign ঊ (*mu*) plus খ (*kh*), silent at the end — one bare consonant again: *mukh*, not *mukho*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

মুখ is a **tatsama**, taken whole from Sanskrit মুখ (*mukha*) — a tadbhava twin, মু (*mu*), also exists, but only buried inside compound words, never standing alone. What makes মুখ worth pausing on is where *mukha* itself came from, and nobody fully agrees. One well-known account, Pokorny's, derives it from **Dravidian**, a language family with no Sanskrit or PIE connection at all. Another, Mayrhofer's, argues for an **Indo-European** source instead, pointing to the word's presence in the Rigveda and in Iranian languages as evidence it is old enough to be inherited rather than borrowed. Both scholars are serious; neither has won. The honest report is that মুখ's deepest root is still an open question.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mukh” — mouth, face
- “āmār mukh” — my face
- the two rival accounts — “Dravidian ... or Indo-European”
- an eye, then a mouth — “chokh ... mukh”

Before you move on

Give “my face” in Bengali. (আমার মুখ.) Is মুখ's ultimate origin settled? (**No** — genuinely disputed between a Dravidian and an Indo-European account.) What is মুখ's tadbhava twin, and where does it survive? (মু, **only inside compound words, never alone.**)

12.3 নাক (nāk) — “nose,” the same word as English’s, worn down differently

মুখ’s origin was an open argument. This one is settled, and it lands somewhere you have seen before.

You’ll want to know: নাক

নাক — *nāk* — nose

আমার নাক (*āmār nāk*) — my nose.

The letters in this word

নাক is ন with the vowel sign া (*nā*) plus ক (*k*), silent at the end: *nāk*, not *nāko*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নাক is Sanskrit नस् (*nas*), inherited through Prakrit णक्का — a tadbhava, like ভাই and বোন before it. Its PIE root is **néh₂s-*, and this one is as secure as roots get: it is the direct ancestor of English **nose** itself, and of Latin **nāsus**, which gives English **nasal**. Three languages, one inherited word, three different roads of sound change — Bengali’s road ran the vowel through Prakrit’s *a*, dropped Sanskrit’s final *-s*, and doubled the *k* along the way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāk” — nose
- “āmār nāk” — my nose
- the three cousins — “nāk ... nose ... nāsus”
- three of this chapter’s words — “chokh ... mukh ... nāk”

Before you move on

Give “my nose” in Bengali. (আমার নাক.) Which two English words share নাক’s root directly? (Nose, and nasal by way of Latin *nāsus*.) Is that link as secure as মুখ’s, or more so? (More — নাক’s root is settled; মুখ’s is still argued over.)

12.4 হৃদয় (hriday) — “heart,” the oldest cousin this book has shown you

Three body words, three different histories — half-worn, disputed, and settled. This last one closes the chapter on the most secure cousin of them all.

You’ll want to know: হৃদয়

হৃদয় — *hriday* — heart

আমার হৃদয় (*āmār hriday*) — my heart.

The letters in this word

হৃদয় is হ with the vowel sign ্র (hri, the “vocalic r” sign, a vowel Bengali keeps only in words borrowed from Sanskrit) plus দ (*dô*) plus য় (*yô*, a glide, not a plain stop — this is why the word ends audibly, *-doy*, rather than falling silent the way দুধ and নাক did).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

হৃদয় is a **tatsama**, Sanskrit হৃদয় (*hṛdaya*) taken whole. A *tadbhava* twin also exists, হিয়া (*hiya*), but it lives in poetry and song rather than everyday speech — the reverse of মুখ’s pair, where the tatsama is the everyday word. Inside হৃদয় sits হৃদ্ (*hṛd*), and its PIE root is ***kérd-**, “heart” — the direct ancestor of English **heart** itself, Greek **kardía** (English **cardiac**), and Latin **cor** (English **core**, **courage**). Four languages, one root, and nowhere in this book has the family been so wide or so certain.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hridoy” — heart
- “āmār hridoy” — my heart
- the wide family — “hṛd ... heart, kardía, cor”
- all four of this chapter’s words — “chokh, mukh, nāk, hridoy”
- one more word from Chapter 11, sharing this lesson’s warmth of feeling — “bhāi,” brother

Before you move on

Give “my heart” in Bengali. (আমার হৃদয়.) Name three English words that share হৃদয়’s root. (**Heart, cardiac, core** — or **courage**.) Two quick reaches further back: what does the dot under ড় tell you to do, the letter পড়া taught? (**Flap it**, curling the tongue back.) And what does the ending -আনো do to a verb, the way ভাবা showed on দেখা? (**Hands the doing to someone else** — দেখা “see” becomes দেখানো “show.”)

The Bengali script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words. This page gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in vowel — and it is ô, not “a.”** ক kô, ন nô, ম mô — written left to right under a connecting top line, like Devanagari but with rounder shapes. This single fact ($a \rightarrow \hat{o}$) is why Sanskrit words sound “Bengali.”
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** কা kâ, কি ki, কী kī, কু ku, কে ke, কো ko. The *i*-signs ি/ী are written *before* the consonant but read *after* it. A *chandrabindu* ঁ nasalises the vowel.
3. **Standalone vowels have their own letters.** A vowel that *starts* a word is written in full: আ ā, অ ô, ই i, উ u, এ e, ও o.

Worth flagging

- **$s \rightarrow$ “sh.”** The letter স (and শ, ষ) is usually pronounced “sh” — আসি is *āshi*, not *āsi*.
- **No separate *v* or *w*.** Bengali has only ব *b*, so Sanskrit *vāda* $\rightarrow$ *bād*, *Vishnu* $\rightarrow$ *Bishnu*.
- **Conjuncts.** A *hasanta* strips a consonant’s vowel so it fuses with the next: স্ + ক $\rightarrow$ স্ক, চ + ছ $\rightarrow$ চ্ছ. Many conjuncts have special shapes you learn as you meet them.

Bengali in the family

Bengali (*Bāṅglā*) is **Indo-Aryan** — from Sanskrit, like Hindi, Marathi, and Punjabi — and its script descends, with Devanagari, from the old Brahmi writing of India, which is why they share the hanging top line. It is spoken across West Bengal (India) and Bangladesh, and carries an immense literary tradition — Tagore’s poetry, the anthems of two countries. The lessons trace its Sanskrit roots and, where they reach, the wider Indo-European family that also shaped English.